

Learning Languages: Unlocking Paths to New Horizons

Written by: Karen Jia

Published: February 22, 2026

At the beginning of English class, my teacher posed the following question to me and my eighth grade classmates: “Where do you think you would find the oldest, continuously-operating university in the world?” We each wrote our responses on a piece of paper. Afterward, my teacher asked everyone to share their answers.

An overwhelming majority of students responded with cities like “Oxford” or “Boston,” instinctively associating intellectual longevity with Western institutions. To our surprise, my teacher revealed that the right answer was, in fact, the University of al-Qarawiyyin, recognized by Guinness World Records and UNESCO as the oldest operating university in the world. This university is located in Fez, Morocco and was founded in the year 859 AD by Fatima al-Fihri during the Islamic Golden Age. It was one of the greatest leading educational institutions of its time.

My classmates’ homogenous answers revealed more than a gap in historical knowledge; they reflected how centuries of Western imperialism and globalization have positioned Western knowledge as the default. The problem was not that my classmates were unintelligent—it was that many of us had been limited to a single culture, and thus, world view.

Expanding our cultural knowledge can break through this mindset. Learning new languages is not merely a tool for communication; it reshapes how we think, broadens our empathy, and enables individuals— and therefore societies— to engage with the world in a more thoughtful and responsible manner.

I grew up in a bilingual household with Chinese immigrant parents. Although it is common among immigrant families to prioritize teaching English to their children to fit in, my parents insisted on speaking Chinese at home. Looking back, I am grateful for every daily conversation and every annual summer trip to China. Maintaining Chinese preserved my connection to my heritage and expanded my worldview.

Thanks to my access to another language, I consumed English and Mandarin media, noticing differences in culture. Over time, I realized that certain Chinese words and expressions even carried nuances in meanings that could not be fully translated into English. Now I can acknowledge that learning languages is truly the best way to understand a culture fully.

This personal experience aligns with research. Studies by the [International Baccalaureate Organization](#) show that multilingual people often demonstrate stronger executive function

and cognitive flexibility because they constantly manage multiple linguistic systems. Switching between languages strengthens attention control and the ability to adapt to new information. Longitudinal research even suggests that bilingualism may [delay age-related cognitive decline](#), reinforcing that language learning strengthens the brain across a lifetime.

Furthermore, language learning fosters identity and confidence. Especially for speakers who have a familial or ancestral tie to a language, [maintaining their native language strengthens self-understanding and connection to family history](#). As scholar Fantini [argues](#), entering another worldview through language cultivates appreciation for the diversity and richness of human experience.

Starting elementary school, I began studying French and Japanese. With each new set of vocabulary, grammar, and ideas I was introduced to, I was putting on a different set of glasses to interpret the world. By communicating with speakers of different languages, one naturally becomes aware that no perspective is universal.

Despite these proven facts, some argue that language learning isn't that essential. Particularly with artificial intelligence on the rise, translating between languages has become more convenient than ever.

Still, digital translators can't keep up with cultural fluency; they fail to capture the different worldviews that a different culture brings to the table. As stated before, many ideas and values aren't able to be directly translated as they may have originated independently through a certain culture. Lack of ability to interpret and transmit human emotions results in inflexible interactions.

The benefits of learning multiple languages extend beyond the individual. In the United States, Western culture is often regarded as the default. This subtle standard can cause limited thinking, lack of creativity, and ignorance perhaps can even evolve into arrogance. It is important to note that this does not mean rejecting Western culture, ideas, and values, but recognizing that when a single narrative dominates, our ability to question it weakens. Learning new languages can prevent this and widen the horizons of every person.

According to the [Center for Applied Linguistics](#), people who are fluent in more than one language contribute significantly in fields like trade, diplomacy, healthcare, and national security. The United States also just happens to be a nation of immigrants from all across the world. Diverse languages bring diverse ways of thinking, and that is what makes our society stronger.

Globally, language learning promotes cooperation and mutual respect. [Societies benefit economically, politically, and socially when citizens can communicate across cultural boundaries](#). Being exposed to different languages teaches us to see differences in perspectives that we can learn from. Only after understanding each other can we cooperate and move forward as global citizens.

The question my English teacher asked that morning was not really about geography. It was about perspective. Why did so many of us instinctively center our answers on the West? Because language and culture quietly shape what we assume to be the academic center of the world.

Language is more than a tool for communication; it is a lens through which we interpret the world around us. Essentially, it's important for us to seek out perspectives that are different from what we're used to. This way, we are less likely to limit ourselves to one way of thinking. By learning new languages, we unlock not only new cultures, but new ways of thinking— and move closer to becoming more thoughtful individuals, a stronger nation, and a more cooperative global community.

Footnotes:

"11 Benefits of Learning a Second Language at an Early Age." Brighter Futures Indiana, 2025, brighterfuturesindiana.org/blog/11-benefits-of-learning-a-second-language-at-an-early-age.

"ACTFL | the Benefits of Learning Languages." ACTFL, 2024, www.actfl.org/advocacy-and-public-education/the-benefits-of-learning-languages.

Fantini, Alvino E. "Language and Worldview." *The Journal of Baha'i Studies*, vol. 2, no. 2, 1989, pp. 13–18, bahai-studies.ca/wp-content/uploads/2014/05/2.2-Fantini.pdf, [https://doi.org/10.31581/jbs-2.2.2\(1989\)](https://doi.org/10.31581/jbs-2.2.2(1989)).

Kroll, Judith F, and Paola E. Dussias. "The Benefits of Multilingualism to the Personal and Professional Development of Residents of the US." *Foreign Language Annals*, vol. 50, no. 2, 18 May 2017, pp. 248–259, www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC5662126/, <https://doi.org/10.1111/flan.12271>.

Marcos, Kathleen. "Ñandutí >>Benefits of Early Learning." [Www.cal.org](http://www.cal.org), www.cal.org/earlylang/benefits/marcos.html.

Nikolov, Marianne, and Shelagh Rixon. *THE BENEFITS of LEARNING ADDITIONAL LANGUAGES*. June 2025.